Authority in Words: Stance Modal Verbs and Directives in Presidents Nelson and Benson's Talks

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Abstract

This study examines the use of modal verbs of stance in General Conference addresses by Presidents Russell M. Nelson and Ezra Taft Benson of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. It investigates how the two leaders differ in their use of advice modals (i.e., *should, must, might, may, could*) and whether they favor personal or collective directives (e.g., "You should" vs. "We should").

Grounded in Biber et al.'s (2002) categorization of modal verbs and Celce-Murcia and Larsen-Freeman's (1999) distinction between logical probability and social interaction modal verbs, this study focuses on ability/permission and obligation modal verbs. D'Hertefelt's (2017) work on directive conditional and complement insubordination further informs the analysis of directive structures used by these prophets. A corpus of 41 talks (48,966 words) from President Nelson and 27 talks (58,516 words) from President Benson were analyzed using AntConc software.

Findings reveal that there is an insignificant difference between President Nelson's and President Benson's use of modal verbs. President Benson more frequently employs collective directives, whereas President Nelson favors personal directives, reflecting differences in their rhetorical leadership styles.

This project, conducted under faculty mentorship, adheres to ethical research standards and contributes to understanding linguistic patterns in religious discourse.

Keywords: modal verbs, stance, directive

Introduction

This comparative study examines the use of modal verbs in the talks given by President Russell M. Nelson and President Ezra Taft Benson (of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints) when they served as prophets and leaders of the church. President Nelson serves the church today and has since 2018, totaling 6 years and counting as president. President Benson served from 1985-1994 (9 years). This study also examines and analyzes their uses and preferences of directive speech, specifically pronouns that indicate personal directives (such as "you should") and collective directives (e.g., "we should").

Modal verbs express stance meanings, conveying an opinion or an attitude on a particular topic or issue from the writer or speaker (Biber et al., 2002, p. 174). Stance is different depending on the type of modal verb, implying that the message is optional or obligatory. Modal verbs function as auxiliary verbs and include the following words: *can, could, will, would, shall, should, may, might*, and *must* (Biber et al., 2002, p. 104). These usually precede main or lexical verbs and never change their form. Listed below is an example of the use of modal verbs, taken from one of President Nelson's talks (italics have been added to show modal verbs):

a) "Our prayers *can* be—and *should* be—living discussions with our Heavenly Father" (Nelson, 2023).

According to Biber et al. (2002), modal verbs are divided into three groups based on their semantic meanings: permission (or ability), obligation (or necessity), and volition (or prediction) (176). The modals within the permission category include *could, may*, and *might*. On the other hand, the modals that are considered to have a stance of obligation are *should* and *must*. Lastly, the volition modal verbs are *will* and *would*. For the purpose of this study and paper, the frequency of modal verb usage from the categories of ability/permission and obligation will be

analyzed to identify their stance meanings within the president's talks. These modal verbs also imply that the message is one of advice, hence why they've been labeled as advice modal verbs for the purpose of this study. Because of the overlap of how the word '*will'* changes the tenses of verbs as well as expresses speaker stance, this paper will forgo analyzing the modal verbs from that category. Volition modal verbs also don't express advice.

Directives are words and language that "are aimed at provoking an action from the addressee: orders, commands, requests" (Kissine, 2013, p. 102). They are usually spoken by those who have power and leadership within a social group or community. This concept pairs well with modal verbs in that they both seek to convey an important message from someone in a position of power. Personal directives are aimed at individuals – the 'others' or addressees of the speaker. Collective directive speech, on the other hand, is directed at the group as a whole, including the speaker in the command, order, or request. For this study, the pronouns "you" and "we" will serve to indicate what kind of directive it is.

Through this research, the goal is to see how the rhetorical styles of prophets have changed over time. My interest in this topic stems from my background in linguistics and observations of how LDS religious leaders use language to guide and influence their audiences. While some research has examined modal verbs in general discourse, little has been done on their use in religious settings, particularly in religious leadership communication. This study seeks to fill that gap by analyzing how modal verbs and directives shape the rhetorical styles of my religion's leaders. They represent the different eras of church leadership, providing a unique opportunity to compare how language use reflects shifting leadership approaches. By examining stance modal verbs and directive speech, this research aims to understand how their linguistic choices shape their messages and influence their audiences. This research contributes to the

broader discussion on how language reflects authority and persuasion in religious discourse, offering insights into the communication styles of Latter-day Saint leaders.

Literature Review

Modal verbs have been discussed extensively by Biber et al. (2002) as well as Celce-Murcia and Larsen-Freeman (1999) and many others. Between the two authors, there is a difference in how modal verbs are categorized. Celce-Murcia and Larsen-Freeman (1999) categorize modal verbs into "logical probability" and "social interaction" based on their different functions (141). Comparatively, as mentioned above, Biber et al. (2002, p. 176) categorize modal verbs into three categories: ability/permission, obligation/necessity, and volition/prediction. Both authors divide modal verbs into categories for personal or social reasons and for logical reasons when construing different meanings. This study will focus more on personal and social categories rather than logical because of the nature of the prophets' talks being an avenue for advice and social influence. The social modal verbs will be considered advice modal verbs.

The authors also explore how the stances of modal verbs influence the semantics of the phrases in which they appear. Biber et al. (2002, p. 178) elaborate on how modals are used across 4 registers, specifically academic prose, news, conversation, and fiction. Although religious texts are not highlighted in the literature cited in this paper, the research and writings found therein are still applicable to the kinds of social registers. Their talks employ modal verbs and directives in ways that convey meaning and stance for their messages, as well as social influence (as mentioned above). The presidents' high position of power within the church at different times also makes the modal verbs more impactful to its audience.

In regards to directive speech, the literature has stated that there are two types of directive meanings: “conditional insubordination” and “complement insubordination” (D’Hertefelt, 2017, p. 209). Conditional insubordination includes speech such as requests and threats; it is based on a conditional outcome. Complement insubordination includes orders, prohibitions, permission, and advice (D’Hertefelt, 2017, p. 233). The latter is more encouraging and warm, while the former is harsher and stricter. Considering that the prophets are charged by the church and its adherents to speak as if from the mouth of God, this study will focus only on complement insubordination directives, following their belief that God is loving and caring. Also, advice falls within the category of complement insubordination and relates directly to advice modal verbs. Additionally, after further review of the religious texts, it was noted that the two prophets’ use of complement insubordination constitutes significantly more of their discourse than conditional. Complement insubordination also encompasses personal and collective directives.

It was assumed that President Nelson would use more ability modal verbs (such as *could* and *may*) rather than obligation modal verbs (such as *must* and *should*), as evident in his more subtle and indirect nature of speech. In contrast, it was assumed that President Benson’s talks demonstrated more obligation modals due to his reputation as being more forthright and direct in his communication. It was also assumed that President Benson'sF would use more personal directive speech while President Nelson would use more collective directive speech. In order to gain more understanding of their distinctive discourse style through their use of ability and obligation modals and directives, the following research questions will be addressed.

1. How do the two leaders differ in their use of advice modals (i.e., *should, must, might, may, could*) in their General Conference talks?

2. How do the leaders differ in their use of personal vs. collective directive pronouns when employing advice modals (i.e., "you should" vs. "we should")?

Methods

Corpus.

For this study, two corpora were created and examined using AntConc software (Anthony, 2024). The first one contains 41 General Conference talks given by President Nelson from April 2018 up until October 2023. The other corpus contains 27 General Conference talks given by President Benson from his time as prophet (1985-94). Their other addresses, such as face-to-face events or devotionals, have not been utilized for this study. President Nelson's corpus consists of 48,966 words and contains 41 text documents, with each conference talk constituting one document. President Nelson delivered all of his talks orally, which were then transcribed into written form. President Benson's corpus consists of 58,516 words and 27 text documents. Every talk was retrieved from The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints website.

Procedures.

The following modals were first searched individually: *could, may, might, must,* and *should* using the keyword in context (KWIC) window in the AntConc software. After the individual searches, it was clear that a search needed to be conducted for all the modal verbs in question (i.e., *could, may, might, must, should*). Using the *Advance Search* feature on AntConc, the initial comprehensive frequency of advice modal verbs totaled 193 times in President Nelson's talks, while the initial comprehensive frequency of President Benson's talks was 405.

The advice modal verb “could” has multiple meanings in different contexts that may suggest ability rather than advice, which could not be specified using the corpus software; thus, “could” was isolated and analyzed. The entries in AntConc for “could” were copied and transferred into an excel sheet in order to make research and comparison easier. A code was created for analysis to determine how many “could” phrases fell under the ability category and how many fell into the advice category. Each entry was read, the number 0 was labeled to those entries that were ability modal verbs, and the number 1 was labeled to the ones that were advice modals of “could.” The *could* advice modal verbs were totaled and added to the results of the data, excluding the ability ones.

To find the directive speech in the texts, the sort left feature in the AntConc software was used to look up “you ___” or “we ____”. Upon further searching, it was evident that a search for “may you” also needed to be conducted because of the idiomatic and frequent use by both prophets and because its meaning falls under the advice category.

Finally, a chi-square test was conducted to assess whether the differences in modal verb usage between the two leaders were statistically significant.

Results and Discussion

Research Question #1. How do the two leaders differ in their use of advice modals (i.e., should, must, might, may, could) in their General Conference talks?

Frequency, in this study, refers to the number of times each verb appears throughout all the text documents. The totals were calculated as well. Listed below are the data for the frequency of use of advice modal verbs for each of the prophets.

Advice Modal Verbs

Ability/Permission Modal Verbs	President Nelson	President Benson
Could	6	13
May	104	127
Might	19	29
TOTAL	**129**	**169**

Obligation/Necessity Modal Verbs	President Nelson	President Benson
Must	12	95
Should	29	119
TOTAL	**41**	**214**

For the ability/permission modals, the chi-square test resulted in a chi-square statistic of 1.61 ($p = 0.447$), indicating no statistically significant difference between the two leaders. For obligation/necessity modals, the chi-square test yielded a statistic of 2.64 ($p = 0.104$). This means there is little to no difference in the use of obligation modal verbs (*must* and *should*) between Presidents Nelson and Benson. However, the p-value is lower than in the ability/permission category, suggesting a trend toward a difference, though not strong enough to be statistically significant. This differs from the assumption made earlier that President Nelson would use more ability/permission modal verbs.

Looking at them individually, this data confirms the assumption that Ezra Taft Benson used more obligation modal verbs (214 total) in his talks instead of ability/permission modal verbs (169 total), suggesting he employs a stricter expression of language overall when giving

advice. It also confirms that President Nelson employs ability and permission modal verbs (129 total) more than he does obligation (41 total), suggesting that he may hedge his language to sound more appealing and softer to his audience.

Overall, the results of this research question imply that there is not a significant difference between the two prophets, though they each favor one type of advice modal verbs in their respective speeches. Individually, President Nelson uses permission or ability verbs more often than obligation verbs in an effort to guide the members rather than dictate. He might do this in order to guide the members of the church rather than dictate exactly what they should do. His talks have reflected a greater emphasis on personal agency, encouraging members to rely on God for answers instead of men. On the other hand, President Benson preferred obligation advice modals over using ability advice modal verbs in his talks. His data suggest that he exercised his leadership to outline exactly what the members should do rather than leave his advice open to interpretation, which created a harsher rhetoric. Perhaps President Benson was more concerned about having clear authority, especially in the way he spoke. He may have felt compelled to use the more direct forms of speech because he felt an urgent need to strongly encourage members of the church to obey the commandments. Under President Nelson's leadership, it can be assumed that a shift has occurred from relying on the church to tell members what to do to relying on personal feelings, God, and the Holy Spirit to guide the members' values and choices. It implies that his leadership is founded on directing the church's followers more than it is laying down the law, while President Benson exemplifies somewhat more of the opposite.

Research Question #2. How do the leaders differ in their use of personal vs. collective directives when employing advice modals (i.e., "you should" vs. "we should")?

Again, frequency is used to determine the number of times each president used directive pronouns to convey personal and collective messages. Listed in the tables below are the data.

Directive Speech

Personal Directive (you) + modal verb	**President Nelson**	**President Benson**
You could	1	1
You may	24	12
May you	2	4
You might	4	0
You must	0	8
You should	2	12
TOTAL	**33**	**37**

Collective Directive (we) + modal verb	**President Nelson**	**President Benson**
We could	1	0
We may	11	6
May we	6	13
We might	2	2
We must	2	48
We should	6	20
TOTAL	**28**	**89**

For personal directives, a chi-square statistic of 23.66 ($p = 0.00025$) indicated a significant difference in how the two leaders employ personal directive modal verbs. Looking at

collective directives, the chi-square test resulted in a chi-square statistic of 31.73 ($p = 0.00000672$), confirming a highly significant difference.

Comparatively, the presidents differ in how they frame their modal verbs with directive speech. As shown in the tables and chi-square data, it is evident that President Benson uses significantly more collective directive messages than President Nelson Under his leadership, many of President Benson's talks were titled "To the ____ (e.g., young women, home teachers, youth, etc.) of the Church," signifying that he had a direct message for that group of people. This is interesting considering he used more collective directives rather than personal, implying that he included himself in the group of the message.

Individually, President Nelson used personal directive speech more so than he did collective directive speech. This suggests that he wanted to address his audience from a removed perspective, not including himself. For example, one of his entries said, "May you seek and receive personal revelation during these sessions, I pray in the sacred name of Jesus Christ, amen" (Nelson, 2022). He urged the members to pay attention to the other talks, emphasizing the importance for members themselves to do that rather than himself.

In contrast, President Benson used more collective directive speech, such as, "Brethren, may we remember all of our individuals and families and "number" them each month and nourish them by the good word of God to keep them in the right way" (Benson, 1987). This indicates that he was including himself, along with the home teachers of the church, in the charge of remembering families and nourishing them. He recognized the importance for himself to adhere to the message he gave. The directive pronouns before the modal verbs were telling as to *what* was important for the prophets to give advice on and *who* it was meant for.

Overall, the results reveal that while President Nelson and President Benson demonstrate similar usage patterns for ability and obligation-related modal verbs, they differ significantly in their use of directive speech. President Benson appears to favor stronger modal verbs in personal directives (e.g., "You must"), whereas President Nelson employs more permissive or guiding language. In collective directives, President Benson's frequent use of "We must" suggests a more urgent and prescriptive tone compared to President Nelson's approach.

These findings align with broader linguistic patterns observed in religious discourse, where leaders tailor their rhetorical style to their doctrinal and cultural context. The significant differences in personal and collective directives may reflect shifts in leadership communication strategies over time.

Conclusion

The purpose of this study was to research and analyze the frequency of advice modal verbs (ability and obligation modal verbs) in order to decipher the stances and styles of speech of President Nelson's and Benson's General Conference addresses. Also researched and analyzed were the directive forms of speech each president used. Biber et al. (2002) and Celce-Murcia & Larsen-Freeman (1999) had different ways of defining and categorizing modal verbs, but the framework outlined by Biber et al. (2002) was the basis that guided this study, especially in comparing ability and obligation advice modal verbs of stance. Overall, it was found that President Nelson's talks were more encouraging and guiding rather than demanding or strict because he used more ability modals than obligation. In contrast, President Benson used more obligation than ability modal verbs in his speeches. Compared to each other, there wasn't a significant difference in their use of advice modal verbs.

This study highlights notable differences in the use of directive modal verbs between President Nelson and President Benson. The two prophets used very similar usages of personal directives, but President Benson exceeded President Nelson in his use of collective directive phrases. The findings contribute to the understanding of rhetorical strategies in religious discourse and open avenues for further research on how leadership communication evolves in religious contexts.

The results may have yielded different implications had the study also included more of President Nelson's addresses to better equal the number of words as President Benson's. This might have shown a more accurate comparison but in an effort to align with the research questions and study their words while in their roles as president of the church, there was a natural difference in the amount of words between the two. Future studies could explore additional linguistic features, such as hedging devices and intensifiers, to provide a more comprehensive view of rhetorical style in religious leadership.

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